

The Grafter Platform — Founder Briefing

To: Rachel Murphy, Founder & CEO — The Grafter

From: The Cyber Boardroom (Customer)

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Subject: Platform Evolution Proposal — Open Source, Graph-Driven, AI-Native

Why This Document Exists

The Cyber Boardroom is a Grafter community member and customer. We've been using the platform, and we believe there's an opportunity to significantly accelerate its impact. This briefing lays out a proposal for evolving the platform — not as outside consultants, but as a customer who wants to contribute.

Everything described here will be published openly under Creative Commons, and any tooling under open-source licences. We're putting our money where our mouth is on the open approach we're advocating.

What The Grafter Has Already Nailed

Before getting into proposals, it's worth naming what's working — because this isn't a rebuild, it's an evolution.

The methodology is proven. Over 30 businesses supported, two successful exits delivered, two more in progress, collectively representing over £150m in revenue across healthcare, professional services, and SaaS. The three-pillar framework (Grow & Optimise → Raise Capital → Exit) and the maturity diagnostic model are genuinely differentiated. Most consultancies offer recycled PowerPoint strategies. The Grafter offers lived experience from a twice-exited founder who bootstrapped to eight figures.

The community is real. The WhatsApp group, the events, the relationships — this isn't a manufactured network. People know each other. They have each other's phone numbers. The Founders Programme builds genuine depth. This is a massive asset that most platforms would kill for.

The content depth is extraordinary. The 200-page playbook and 400-slide deck represent years of distilled expertise. The diagnostic tool that assesses business maturity across every dimension — strategy, finances, IP, operations — is a genuinely powerful framework.

The emotional dimension is rare. Most growth/exit consultancies focus purely on the numbers. The Grafter's explicit focus on the emotional readiness of founders — the "softer side" as you've described it — is a genuine competitive advantage. Founders don't just need a valuation; they need someone who's walked the path and can sit alongside them through the process.

The Opportunity

The platform has digitised the playbook into an online diagnostic with forms, questions, and AI-assisted outputs. This was a sensible first step. But adoption tells a story: the current approach asks too much of the user and returns too little context in exchange.

The core challenge is that the platform currently works like a compliance exercise. Users answer open-ended questions ("What's your go-to-market strategy?"), feel exposed by what they don't know, and receive recommendations that aren't connected to their specific situation. The community directory

requires manual profile creation when most of this data is already public. And the underlying data is locked in an opaque backend with no easy way to export, connect to, or build on top of it.

The opportunity is to flip this completely — and in doing so, create something that could become the defining platform for the founder growth-to-exit journey.

The Proposal: Three Shifts

Shift 1: From "Tell Us Everything" to "Confirm What We Found"

Instead of asking founders to fill in forms, the platform should do the work first. Give it a URL, a LinkedIn profile, a voice memo, or a brain dump — and it extracts, structures, and presents what it found. The founder's job becomes confirming or correcting, not generating from scratch.

This is dramatically easier for users. "Is this correct?" requires a fraction of the cognitive effort of "What is your strategy?" And it produces better data, because it's grounded in real-world information rather than aspirational answers.

The maturity diagnostic — which is genuinely one of the strongest parts of the offering — becomes far more powerful when it's pre-populated with extracted context rather than starting from zero.

Shift 2: From Static Checklists to a Living Graph

Every data point, recommendation, and connection in the platform should be linked. When the platform says "you need to strengthen your IP documentation," the founder should be able to see exactly which data points drove that conclusion — and when those data points change, the recommendations should update.

This turns the platform from a one-time report into a living advisory system. It also enables something powerful: showing founders how their graph connects to other community members' graphs. Not just a directory of names, but an active connection engine — "this person has solved the exact problem you're facing" or "this founder's business is complementary to yours."

The WhatsApp community already has the trust layer. The platform should surface the "who should talk to whom and about what" layer on top of it, with mutual opt-in so nobody gets cold-approached.

Shift 3: From Closed Platform to Open Ecosystem

The platform base should be open source, with data stored in simple, portable formats (JSON, file-system-based). Every page should expose its underlying data. Users should be able to export everything.

This isn't giving away the business — it's building the moat. The open-source base drives adoption, trust, and ecosystem growth. Companies can deploy it internally and connect back to the mothership. External tools and agents can integrate with it. The community becomes a network effect, not a walled garden.

The business model shifts to charging for what genuinely requires protection: private strategy data, security features, premium advisory services, and the human expertise layer (which is where The Grafter's real value lives and always will).

What We're Proposing to Do

We're not asking The Grafter to commit to anything yet. What we're proposing is:

1. **Set up a public GitHub repository** under The Cyber Boardroom as a customer engagement workspace. All documents, research, and tooling published openly.

2. **Run a technical discovery** with the current Technical Lead (we've prepared an interview brief — structured, collaborative, non-adversarial) to understand the existing architecture before making any technical recommendations.
3. **Conduct public research** on The Grafter's existing platform, content, and ecosystem to build a comprehensive picture of what exists.
4. **Deploy an agentic team** (architect, cartographer, journalist, librarian, historian, conductor) to work through the architecture, Wardley mapping, and documentation. No developers or DevOps at this stage — this is pure strategy and architecture work.
5. **Deliver a series of open-source briefs and recommendations** that Rachel and the team can evaluate, adopt, modify, or discard as they see fit.

The entire output is a gift to the project. Use what's useful, ignore what isn't.

Why This Matters Now

The advisory and consulting market is being reshaped by AI. Platforms that remain closed, form-heavy, and disconnected will lose to approaches that are contextual, graph-aware, and open. The Grafter has the methodology, the community, and the founder credibility that no AI tool can replicate. The platform just needs to meet that level.

The Grafter's stated mission is to reduce the 80% of UK businesses that never manage to sell. An open, AI-native, graph-driven platform — with The Grafter's proven methodology at its core — could genuinely move that number.

Accompanying Documents

Document	Purpose
Strategic Briefing	Full platform vision: architecture, data model, UX, business model, open-source strategy
Technical Discovery Brief	Structured interview questions for the current Technical Lead
GitHub Repo Brief	Scope and structure for the open-source customer engagement workspace

Next Steps

We'd welcome a conversation to walk through this in more detail. In the meantime, we'll proceed with setting up the public repo and publishing the materials we've already created. Everything is open — Rachel and the team have full visibility from day one.
